

Theme Book Sample

source · github.com/forcewake

Four short chapters on setting text for a 16-gray panel, rendered with `--theme book --sections pages`: Liberation Serif at 1.6 leading, hairline rules, chapters that open their own page.

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On reading longform

The serif theme exists for the documents you will read for an hour rather than annotate: essays, interviews, book chapters, long retrospectives. Its body is set in Liberation Serif at sixteen pixels with one-point-six leading, which sounds like an arbitrary pair of numbers until you hold the tablet. Serif letterforms give the eye more distinguishing detail at e-ink resolutions than geometric sans; the generous leading gives partial-refresh ghosting somewhere harmless to land. Everything else is subtraction. There are no rules heavier than a hairline, no small caps louder than the running head, no color, no fills, no drop caps. Drop caps were tried and rejected: on a panel with sixteen gray levels, a decorative initial is a smudge that the reader pays for on every refresh. The result reads like a trade paperback that happens to weigh four hundred grams and never run out of margin.

The same engine renders this theme and the technical grid you saw at the top of the repository; only the stylesheet differs, and the stylesheet is less than a screenful.

On chapters

Every chapter opens its own page under a thin rule, the way a proper book does, and the title page carries the table of contents with page numbers measured from the rendered document rather than guessed. That last clause matters more than it sounds. Pagination is where naive pipelines lie to you: they compute where sections *should* land, ship a table of contents full of wrong numbers, and let the reader discover the drift on page seventeen. Here the document is rendered once, measured, and rendered again with the truth. A chapter that grows by a paragraph moves every number after it, and the contents page knows.

Chapters are also a pacing device. On a device with no scroll bar, a page turn is the only progress signal; opening a chapter on a fresh page gives the reader a place to stop, which is what chapters are for.

On the compact theme

For manuals and API references there is a third theme — fourteen-point body, tighter leading, the same chrome — packing roughly a fifth more words per page. It exists for the times a document must fit the flight, not the desk. The compact theme is deliberately not the default: density is a cost you pay in margin notes and finger room, and most documents sent to a tablet are read once and deleted, not consulted for a quarter.

Choose it when the document is reference-shaped: numbered sections, tables of parameters, code you will scroll past rather than read. Choose the serif when the document has a voice. Choose the grid when it has a deadline.

On margins that earn their keep

The thirteen-millimeter side margins are not decoration; they are where a thumb rests while the other hand holds a pen, and the fifteen-millimeter bottom margin is where that pen waits between thoughts. Typography that ignores the hand is furniture that ignores the room. The same logic sets the body size: sixteen pixels is exactly twelve points, the floor below which sustained reading on this panel becomes work, verified the hard way by a community that has been arguing about it since the first firmware.

None of these values are fashionable. They are the arithmetic of one specific screen — a thousand four hundred and four by a thousand eight hundred and seventy-two pixels at two hundred twenty-six dots per inch — and the point of the whole pipeline is that you should never have to think about them again.